

NBA Dataset Explained

Rk — Rank

- Just a row number, basically meaningless for analysis

Player — Player Name

- Self explanatory but important — this is your primary identifier
- *Note : names repeat for traded players*

Pos — Position There are 5 real positions in basketball:

Position	Code	Role
Point Guard	PG	Ball handler, playmaker, usually smallest
Shooting Guard	SG	Scorer, 3-point specialist
Small Forward	SF	Versatile, can score and defend
Power Forward	PF	Physical, rebounds, mid-range shots
Center	C	Tallest player, protects the basket

- *Note : There are 12 combos like SG-PF because of trades*

Age

- Age in years during that season

Tm — Team

- 30 NBA teams abbreviated (UTA = Utah Jazz, GSW = Golden State Warriors etc.)
- We also have TOT which means "Total" for traded players -> not a real team!
- Always *filter out TOT when doing team-level analysis*

THE PLAYING TIME COLUMNS

G -> Games Played

- Season is 82 games total
- A player with 82 G played every single game
- *Note : a player with 500 PTS in 20 games is very different from 500 PTS in 80 games*

GS -> Games Started

- How many games they were in the starting lineup vs coming off the bench
- Starters are generally better/more trusted players

MP -> Minutes Played

- Total minutes across the whole season
- More minutes = coach trusts you more
- *Note : high stats with low minutes is very impressive*

THE SHOOTING COLUMNS — This is the heart of the dataset

Think of shooting stats in 3 groups:

All Shots (Field Goals)

FG -> Field Goals Made

- Every shot that went in EXCEPT free throws
- Includes both 2-pointers and 3-pointers

FGA -> Field Goals Attempted

- Every shot taken, whether it went in or not

FG% -> Field Goal Percentage

- Formula: $FG \div FGA$
 - The higher the better — tells you how accurate a shooter is
 - League average is roughly 45-46%
 - *Example: 50% FG% means 1 in every 2 shots goes in*
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3-Point Shots

3P -> 3-Pointers Made

- Shots made from behind the arc (worth 3 points)

3PA -> 3-Pointers Attempted

- 3-point shots taken

3P% -> 3-Point Percentage

- Formula: $3P \div 3PA$
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2-Point Shots

2P -> 2-Pointers Made

- Regular shots inside the arc

2PA -> 2-Pointers Attempted

- 2-point shots taken

2P% -> 2-Point Percentage

- Formula: $2P \div 2PA$
 - Usually higher than 3P% because these shots are closer to the basket
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eFG% — Effective Field Goal Percentage

- This is the SMART version of FG%
 - Regular FG% treats a 3-pointer and 2-pointer the same, but they're not worth the same!
 - eFG% gives 3-pointers extra credit because they're worth more
 - Formula: $(FG + 0.5 \times 3P) \div FGA$
 - *Using eFG% instead of FG% when comparing shooters — it's more honest*
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FREE THROWS

FT -> Free Throws Made

- "Free" shots from the free throw line awarded after being fouled
- Each worth 1 point, taken with no defenders

FTA -> Free Throws Attempted

- How many free throws they took

FT% -> Free Throw Percentage

- Formula: $FT \div FTA$
 - Should be the EASIEST shooting stat, no defender, standing still
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THE REBOUNDING COLUMNS

A rebound = grabbing the ball after a missed shot

ORB -> Offensive Rebounds

- Your team missed a shot and YOU grabbed it -> giving your team another chance
- High ORB = second chance point machine
- Usually dominated by centers and power forwards

DRB -> Defensive Rebounds

- Opponent missed a shot and YOU grabbed it -> ending their possession
- Much more common than offensive rebounds
- *Most rebounds in the dataset are defensive*

TRB -> Total Rebounds

- Simply: $ORB + DRB$
 - The headline rebound number we see on TV
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THE PLAYMAKING & DEFENSE COLUMNS

AST -> Assists

- A pass that directly leads to a teammate scoring
- High assists = unselfish, court-vision player
- Point guards lead this category almost always
- *AST vs TOV -> the assist-to-turnover ratio*

STL -> Steals

- Taking the ball from the opponent
- High steals = quick, instinctive defender

BLK -> Blocks

- Swatting away an opponent's shot
- High blocks = tall, athletic rim protector
- *Centers dominate this stat*

TOV -> Turnovers

- Losing possession through bad passes, stepping out of bounds, getting stolen from
- Lower is better
- *Context matters: ball handlers have more TOV because they touch the ball more*

PF -> Personal Fouls

- Illegal contact with an opponent
 - Max 6 per game before fouling out
 - *High PF players are a game management risk in close games*
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THE RESULT

PTS -> Total Points

- Every point scored all season: 2-pointers + 3-pointers + free throws
 - The most famous stat but NOT the most complete picture
 - *Always pair with FG% or eFG% -> points mean more when scored efficiently*
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